

The `tools` parameter defines which tools an agent can see and potentially use, acting as the primary filter for tool availability. It accepts built-in tools by name (`"read"`, `"shell"`), MCP server tools with `@server_name/tool_name` syntax, or wildcards like `"*"` for all tools and `"@server_name"` for all tools from a specific server.

This parameter determines tool **visibility** rather than permission—tools listed here may still require user confirmation unless also included in `allowedTools`, and can be further restricted through `toolsSettings` for path, command, or service-level security controls.

Objective

Learn how to control which tools agents can access using the `tools` parameter.

Instructions

Step 1: Create Agent with Specific Tools

```
1 cat > .kiro/agents/limited-dev.json << 'EOF'
2 {
3   "name": "limited-dev",
4   "description": "Development assistant with limited tool access",
5   "tools": ["read", "write"]
6 }
7 EOF
```



Step 2: Create Agent with All Tools

```
1 cat > .kiro/agents/full-access-dev.json << 'EOF'
2 {
3   "name": "full-access-dev",
4   "description": "Development assistant with full tool access",
5   "tools": ["*"]
6 }
7 EOF
```



Step 3: Test Tool Access Differences

⚠️ Custom agents with tool `read` must be explicitly specified in `allowedTools` of the JSON file

1. Test Limited Agent:

```
1 kiro-cli chat --agent limited-dev
```



Check available tools in the agent:

```
1 /tools
```



Expected:

```
[limited-dev] > /tools
```

Tool	~Tokens	Permission
Built-in		
- read	870	trusted
- write	490	not trusted

Try these commands:

```
"Read the README.md file"      # Should work (with permission)
"Run 'ping 127.0.0.1' command" # Should be unavailable
"Check AWS S3 buckets"         # Should be unavailable
```

2. Test Full Access Agent:

```
1 kiro-cli chat --agent full-access-dev
```



```
1 /tools
```



Expected:

```
[full-access-dev] > /tools
```

Tool	~Tokens	Permission
Built-in		
- code	1.4k	trust read-only operations
- delegate	620	not trusted
- shell	150	not trusted
- read	870	trusted
- write	490	not trusted
- glob	260	trust working directory
- grep	610	trust working directory
- introspect	230	trusted
- knowledge	1.1k	trusted
- report	-	not trusted
- session	760	not trusted
- thinking	280	trusted (prerelease)
- todo	920	trusted
- aws	420	trust read-only commands
- subagent	850	not trusted
- web_fetch	250	trusted
- web_search	1.0k	trusted
Total	10.3k	

Try the same commands:

```
"Read the README.md file"      # Should work (with permission)
"Run 'ping 127.0.0.1' command" # Should work (with permission)
"Check AWS S3 buckets"         # Should work (with permission)
```

Verification

- ✔ Limited agent only has read and write tools
- ✔ Full access agent has all available tools
- ✔ Unavailable tools show appropriate error messages
- ✔ Available tools still require user permission

Key Learnings

- `tools` parameter controls which tools are available to the agent
- `["*"]` gives access to all available tools
- Specific tool names limit access to only those tools
- Tool availability doesn't affect permission requirements